

Empire of AI is wildly misleading on AI water use

Posted by u/MrMasley • 0 points • 1 comments

Within 20 pages, the author manages to:

- * Imply a data center is using 1000x as much water as a city of 88,000 people, where it's actually using about 22%, and only 3% of the municipal water system the city relies on.
- * Imply that AI data centers will consume 1.7 trillion gallons of drinkable water by 2027, while the study she's pulling from says that only 3% of that will be drinkable water, and 90% will not be consumed, and instead returned to the source unaffected.
- * Paint a picture of AI data centers harming water access in America, where they don't seem to have caused any harm at all.
- * Frame Uruguay as using an unacceptable amount of water on industry and farming, where it actually seems to use the same ratio as any other country.
- * Frame the Uruguay proposed data center as using a huge portion of the region's water where it would actually use ~0.3% of the municipal water system, without providing any clear numbers.

These are all the significant mentions of data centers using water in the book. I document everything in the post itself.

Comments

u/AccomplishedDuck553 • 3 points • 2025-11-16 21:55 UTC

I hate these half-assed articles that show statistics out of all context. Especially the water and electricity ones.